FileRights

What is FileRights?
FileRights is a collaborative programme devised to prevent copyright content from being distributed on the BitTorrent network.

How does it work?
A Web site for original content developers and BitTorrent Web site owners will host a database to which the original content developers can upload details of their movies, TV shows, and songs. FileRights then distributes these details to participating BitTorrent sites so that copyrighted content can be removed from their search results. FileRights will use the file's digital signature, or MD5 checksum—also known as "hash values"—to detect this content over their network.

Why is it a good thing?
Currently, the only way for original content developers to remove their content from a BitTorrent site is to issue Digital Millennium Copyright Act (DMCA) affidavits for each and every torrent file on the site. FileRights will take much less time to implement.

Where lies the problem?
Since FileRights uses hash values to detect content, even the smallest alteration to a file, like the adding of a frame to a video, will make the file unique and untraceable by the database, thereby debunking the entire system. Moreover, Digital Millennium Copyright Act take-down affidavits are worrisome only to BitTorrent sites hosted outside the US.

When did it start?
The FileRights network programme was launched in July 2007.

Who is developing it?
Ironically, the team behind the popular torrent site TorrentSpy, a site that hosts torrent files of pirated content, has developed the system. They hope to rope in more original content developers and BitTorrent sites.

breach the customer's privacy. John Kennedy, chief executive of the International Federation of the Phonographic Industry (IFPI), praised the judgement and commented, "The Internet's gatekeepers, the ISPs, have a responsibility to help control copyright-infringing traffic on their networks." The IFPI represents recording industry worldwide.

However, after this, British ISPs expressed firm discontent against the ruling. The UK's Internet Service Providers Association (ISPA) re-asserted that ISPs should not be held responsible for the music sharing that takes place via P2P networks. According to the eCommerce Directive (of 2002), ISPs are mere conduits of information, noted an ISPA representative.

But certain ISPs have realised their liabilities, and are moving away from being labelled "pure conduits." Danny Prieskel, a telecommunications lawyer, believes that UK ISPs would strongly oppose it if such a liability is imposed upon them. David Cameron, UK Conservative Party leader, said in a speech that if child pornography could be removed by ISPs, then they would block the sharing of copyright-infringing content. In regards this, the ISPA justified themselves saying two different things were being talked about: child pornography is a criminal case, and copyright infringement would be a civil case. Cameron added that Internet censorship should take place at the government level and not a corporate level. *People* are responsible for uploading and sharing of illegal content, not ISPs, he reiterated.

The ISPs seem to be pretty much sick of it, and just want to wash their hands off the issue. If the ISPs were to start examining every data packet transmitted, one can imagine the increase in the workload on systems. It could even cause data congestion and slower speeds.

In India, certain ISPs believe in their own liabilities just to the point where transmission of copyright-infringing content becomes a major issue. However, customers are smart enough to install key-loggers on their systems and put them to surreptitious use, installing several packet masking software, and even employing router hacks. Should ISPs be responsible for what's transmitted across the wires? It's a debate almost as large as that of P2P and DRM itself.

COSYING UP

What Price Privacy?

Here's another case of kiss and make up: earlier this year, Google sued Microsoft in regards Vista because it left no scope for competition—Vista had locked down the Desktop search program. Google wanted to develop search-based products for Vista, and complained against incompatibility issues with the OS.

Microsoft initially called Google's complaints baseless. But the software giant is currently enjoying a boost in their profits—of about 11 per cent—for Vista and other products. And recently, they announced they would change the Desktop search features in the engine. This would allow users and OEMs to choose Desktop search programs in Vista other than Windows Instant Search. This change will be activated from Vista Service Pack 1, due in the last quarter of this year.

Microsoft will provide technical details of the Desktop search to other Desktop search providers so they can design their product for optimisation of computer resources. It will make independent software vendors' search products interoperable with Vista. The royalty-free programme for software vendors will be extended to 18-months.

In July, Microsoft filed a patent for ad-supported desktop search versions. The patent focuses on using software that will display ads after the gathering of information lying on the user's hard drive. Data security would be of the utmost concern, keeping users in mind.

Well done, Microsoft, for patching up with Google. But they are planning to put the security of user at the highest form of risk. The ad version of their desktop search could well create compatibility issues, and raise the risk of malware attacks as well. The adware might even gather information based on the user's files and documents. It's a case of keeping potential lawsuits at bay by giving the users something to worry about. Of course, users will have the option of not installing either a Google or a Microsoft tool, but when they're there, we a believe a large number—if not the majority—will go ahead and do it anyway.

May the mini-drama unfurl! ⊠

■ Apple takes 4th place in notebook sales—behind HP, Toshiba and Gateway ■ Indiana University students phish people to understand the phenomenon and stress importance of security ■